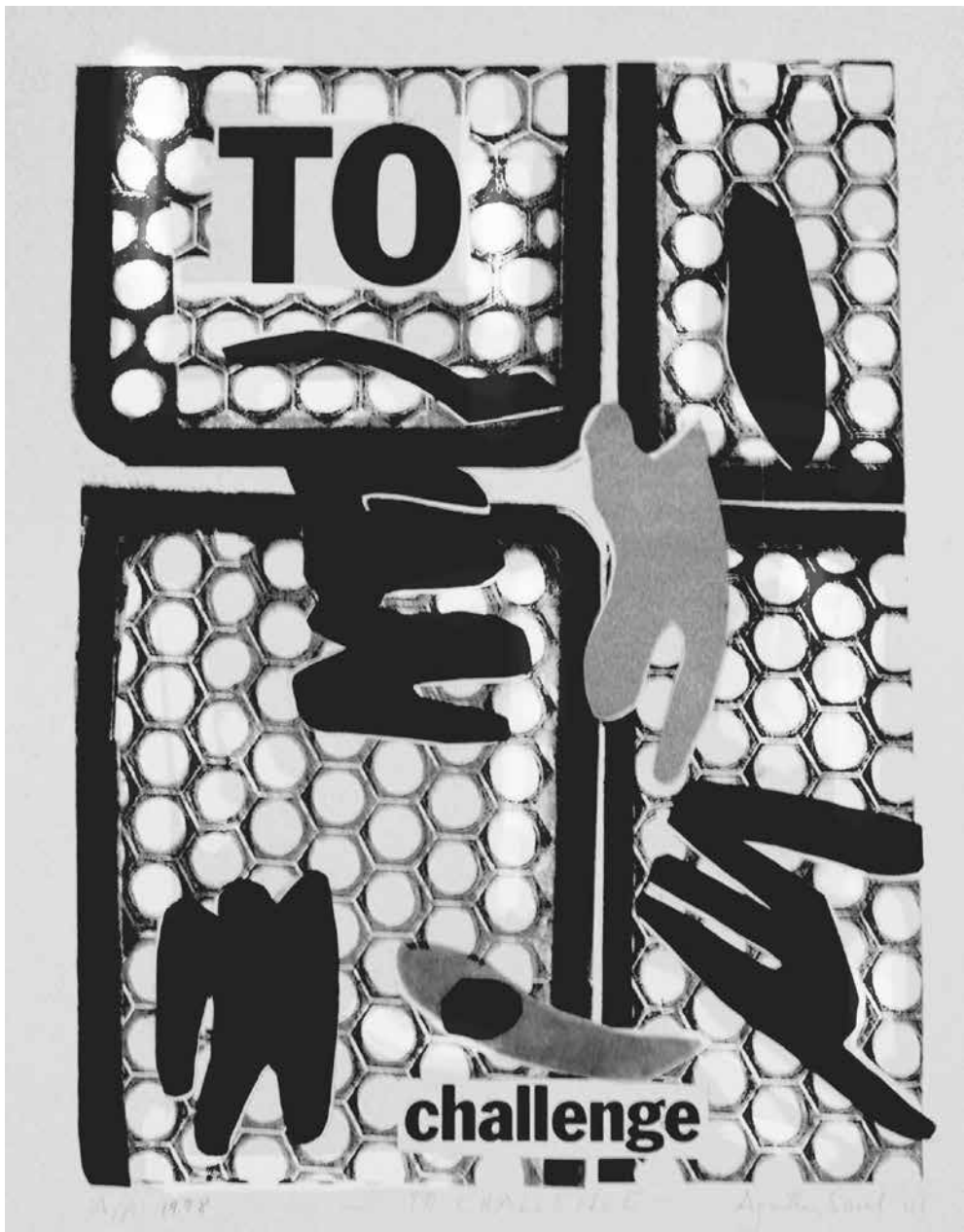


Agathe Sorel

PROJECTIONS IN SPACE AND TIME



Agathe Sorel, To Challenge, engraving, 19xx

Volume Two

Agathe Sorel

PROJECTIONS IN SPACE AND TIME

Limited edition
Studio of Contemporary Art

Note to the reader

Throughout the text there are references to various websites which will give a broader understanding of the topics discussed. A list of these websites is available on Agathe's website, **www.agathesorel.co.uk** on the memoirs page, and are arranged in chapter order according to the text of the book.

For ease of use we recommend that you use the website while reading this book.

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Acknowledgements

Foreword by David Ferry

ENGRAVING, the act of incising a groove into some resistant material, is found as early as the first traces of human activity. Perhaps before speech had reached the point of development when it could adequately impart command or describe experience, the scratching of lines into bone, horn and stone served as a means of communicating ideas and recording experience.'

I first met Agathe in September 1976. The location was the quite modernist looking extension to the much older London County Council Camberwell School of Art and Crafts building on the Peckham Road. A co-existence of style and function.

I had no idea at the time who Stanley Hayter was! Who Agathe Sorel was! What artistic connection was! Or why printmaking was going to be for some of us the essential creative journey it became.

LOCATION: IDEA: and PROCESS hold those thoughts

I still have the experimental etchings and aquatints on steel that I produced with this group of First Year Painting students during her teaching class. A two hour session that was so very different to the silence of the Life Class or the hermetically sealed individual enclosures of the normal painting spaces. The printmaking studio was an organised assembly of machines and extraction ducts, magic water (called acid) and of course the human presence that somehow combined LOCATION, IDEA and PROCESS into that increasingly hysterical but tangible trace of creative matter (the print).

Aircraft cockpit Perspex, an office photocopy machine, a computer, a line incised on a surface, the PRINT in contemporary thinking is not bound by custodial labels; it is fresh and dynamic, bargain basement through to Harrods.

Time and Space merge in our lives, LOCATION, IDEA and PROCESS morph through experience, maturity, and trial and error.

I have been fortunate to have been able to visit Agathe in her different studios, firstly in Parsons Green, then Victoria, Lanzarote and latterly at Dorrell Hall.

I have understood that the magnificent Perspex engraving MACHO THE COCK had its roots in Papagayo on that black ash volcanic island. Agathe took me there once on a dirt road, a white knuckle ride with Macho at the end of it. If we ever had that wonderful creative trinity of LOCATION, IDEA and PROCESS

coming together, it is surely in examples like this.

Of course there are many such equations and expressions in Agathe's overall oeuvre. A collection that has moved through and embraced time, and also I believe always with an accent on a future time, (as though we all need to be reminded of the debate, the next encounter and why should anything stand still).

Agathe Sorel, to my mind, is that essential artist explorer, a true SPACE INVADER, she is my friend and remains a great mentor.

Thank you Agathe for waking me up at 19 years of age and helping me address the future.

David Ferry PRE

*President of the Royal Society of Painter-Printmakers and Professor of Printmaking,
Cardiff Metropolitan University*

Introduction notes by the artist

The first volume of these memoirs is based on the diaries and correspondence of three generations of my family. They also show the little understood social history of Yugoslavia, Transylvania and Hungary for almost two centuries.

I added a lot of detail, to describe the life style and social history in those years as these would be quite unfamiliar to the younger generation; I also found that the devil is in the detail to evoke personal and emotional involvement by the readers. I did not want to sanitize any of the events or to fictionalize them. Real life is sometimes more dramatic than fiction. The events described here might be horrible and frightening, but they must be remembered.

When I finished the first draft of these memoirs, I found much additional material in an abandoned and forgotten drawer of my desk. It contained poignant letters, dramatic and haunting photographs, and contemporary newspaper articles from World War I, mostly from my father's family.

I also found their extensive correspondence and advice from my teacher and mentor Margit Graber, a long letter from my boyfriend Sándor Levai, which I had never read and cannot now respond to as he has been dead for 20 years. I still have to come to terms with this and find out the details, which is difficult as most of the participants are now dead or very old.

I then focus on my own memories of the Holocaust, the end of World War II and the Russian occupation of Hungary in 1956. Some of this was written when I was 9 years old, the rest as a teenager and later a student and young adult.

Nevertheless, I hope the narrative will show the emergence of hope and fulfilment both as an artist and as a mother. Although my husband Gabor and I travelled widely and could have settled anywhere, we came back to England time and time again as we experienced kindness and freedom to live the way we wanted. This does not mean that things were always easy.

In 1961 we became British citizens and could travel, work and live without restrictions; I received the Gulbenkian Scholarship and

other help from the same foundation to set up my studio and exhibit worldwide. In 1966-67 I won a Churchill fellowship to travel and work in the USA and Mexico.

In 1970 my son was born, a real British citizen, who unfortunately never learnt Hungarian. My parents were alas no longer alive to enjoy him. We fought very hard to give him a good education, but it was a worthwhile struggle. He achieved a scholarship to Cambridge in engineering and is now a director of an American IT company. He was lucky enough to marry the love of his life, Alleyna, who is a consultant microbiologist and we now have two lovely grandchildren, for whom I hope this memoir will be valuable when they grow up.

I have been working on my memoirs for almost two years, most intensively in the last six months and I would like to thank the people who helped me in a process, which turned out to be a stiff learning curve.